



DEEP FAITH: Locals believe that Atif, whose ancestral house is now locked from outside to keep away the media, was innocent

dropping dead in the unlikelyst of places or getting detained as mercenaries of an angry god.

This narrative of innocence is repeated by the growing legion of spokesmen of "truth"—truth as different from what is written on the news pages and what is shown on the national television. Surprisingly, it is a well-rehearsed performance by the self-chosen conscience keepers of Azamgarh. Listen to them and realise how far a cursed place can go in defending the indefensible. This is Obaid Ur Rehman, chairman of the nagar panchayat and a local BSP leader: "It's all a police conspiracy to defame Azamgarh. There

though he doesn't say "better future in jihad". Still, he would like "my child to start with a madrasa". Why? "Mother tongue is the best medium." But in Azamgarh today, he says, fear and anger have replaced hope. Scared parents are calling back their children from cities, he tells you. "Let them miss the studies. They will be alive at least." And he too has the final word on truth: "These blasts have nothing to do with Islamic radicalisation, and we have sympathy for them (the Jamia plotters)."

Not far from the tutor's shed, past the house of Atif (who was killed in the police encounter in Delhi), a village congress is in progress in the



FOR THE poorest of Muslim children, education in Azamgarh comes free, though others call it indoctrination.

was no encounter...and tell me, how can a 17-year-old be a mastermind? They all look innocent... I know the family of Atif (who was killed in the encounter). I'm scared as a father; I have three boys studying in Lucknow. When I watch television, I know it's not breaking news but breaking India." How do you know they are innocent? "They look innocent."

A few kilometres away, from a thatched shed, Mosiuddin, who taught both Saif and Arif before they went to Jamia, too gives a "100 per cent innocence certificate" to the boys. "We are practising Muslims but not fanatics, and jihad for us is not exemplified by Osama or Mullah Omar," he says. This private tutor thinks anybody who wants a better future has to learn computer, Arabic and English,

shade of a tree. The young are leaning on their Suzuki bikes or reading the latest on Azamgarh in the newspaper. The eldest, Iqbal Ahmed, his frail frame held aloft by a walking stick, is holding back tears. And the angriest of them all is dissuading others from talking to journalists: "Our boy was killed and you are busy talking to the media." Still, Rizwan Ahmed, a Jamia alumnus who just returned from the Gulf to get married, talks: there is no hope for us here. He is talking about the Muslims of Azamgarh. In the end, it is all about being a Muslim, and suddenly, adjectives like radical and liberal have been made redundant by the rage of identity. This is what Iftekar Ahmed, principal of Azamgarh's premier cultural landmark, Shibli National College, founded by Nomani, has

“ You cannot be secular in India. Even the worst Muslim won't do such a thing during Ramzan. ”

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